

Talkin' Country in W[a:]ne Country

Sociolinguistic Variation in Napa, California

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Background

Metropolitan areas of California have dominated sociolinguistic research on the West Coast. Napa, California has a global reputation for wine tourism but hasn't received attention in the literature.

What is "Country Talk"?

- Employing a combination of rural and Southern dialect features, like the nonstandard *-in* variant (e.g., *walkin'*) and a monophthongal /ay/ vowel [1] (happens in Philly before sonorants)

Research Question

Do Napa, California residents who identify as "Country" use canonical "Country Talk" features to make meaning, and are these features consistent across speakers?

Map of Northern California

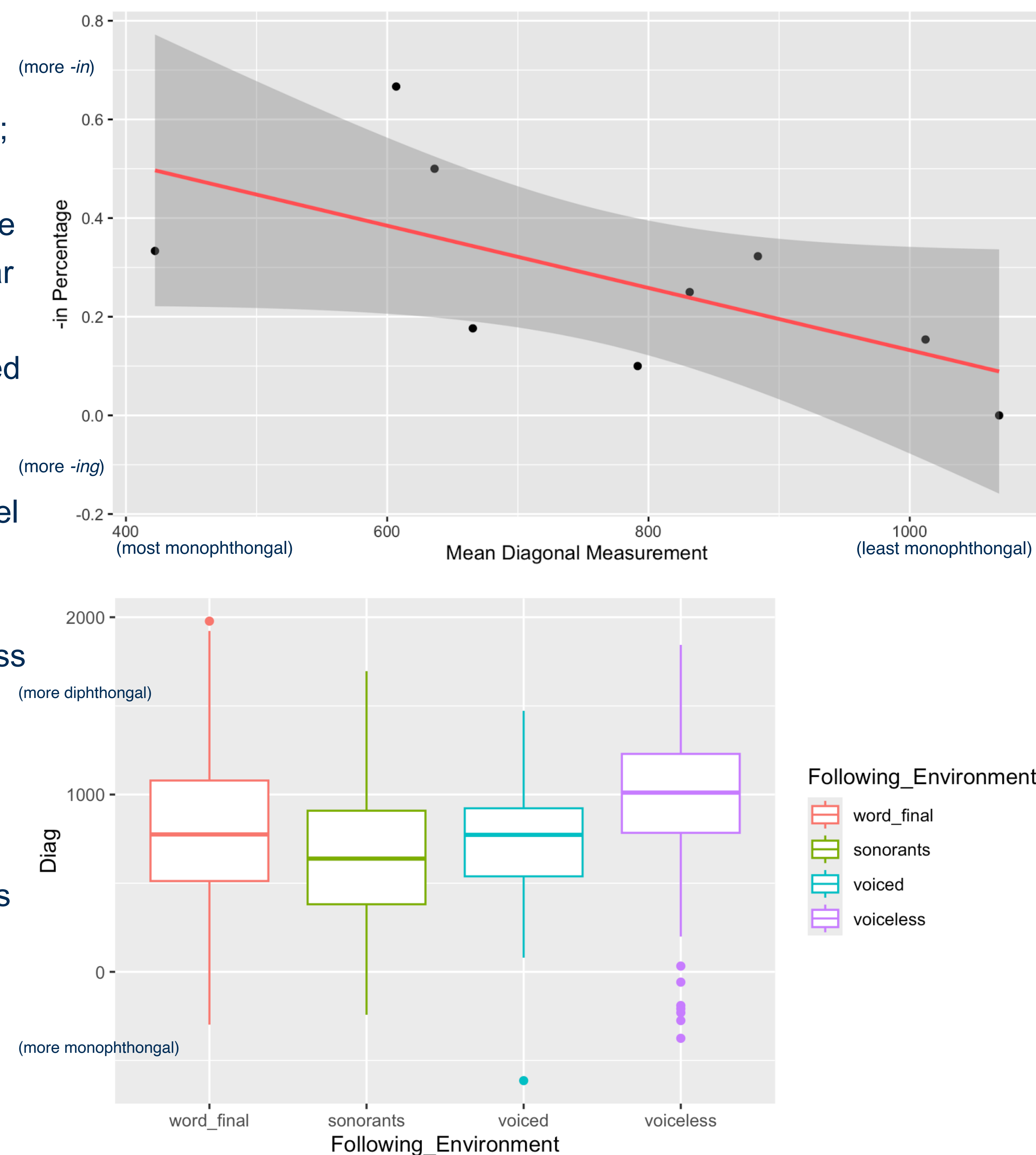


Methods

- Interviewed 9 longtime Napa residents (White; aged 58-86; 5 women, 4 men)
- Tokens of present progressive (ING) from interview and Pear Story narration task (n=447) were impressionistically coded as *-in* or *-ing*
- /ay/ token F1 and F2 were measured at 80% of the vowel duration
- Diagonal measure of combined height and frontness for the glide was calculated with the formula $F2 - 2 * F1$ [2]
- Linear regression model was fit to predict /ay/ diagonal measures (n=900). Predictors included speaker *-in* rates, following environment, and duration

Results

- Participant mean diagonal measurement and *-in* percentage are negatively correlated (est.: -461.19, $p < 0.001$), indicating that more monophthongal /ay/ speakers use the *-in* variant more frequently
- /ay/ tokens were also more diphthongal in pre-voiceless (est.: 327.51, $p < 0.001$) and word-final contexts (est.: 159.34, $p < 0.001$) compared to pre-sonorants (as we would expect for the U.S.)
- Duration is positively correlated with mean diagonal measurements (est.: 1.17, $p < 0.001$), and longer /ay/ tokens were more diphthongal
- Word-final contexts variably patterned with pre-voiceless or pre-sonorants depending on the participant



Conclusion

Discussion:

- in* usage and /ay/-monophthongization pattern together, which is surprising for Californians. Interesting variation in usage of the features despite the participants comprising a relatively homogenous macrosocial category
- /ay/ in word-final contexts variably patterned, warranting further investigation into claims that internal conditioning constraints should be ordered the same across community members [3]

Future directions:

- Expanding to the large Latine community
- Want to do an ethnographic high school study to examine teens' rootedness and relationship to agriculture

References

- [1] Hall-Lew, L., & Stephens, N. (2012). Country Talk. *Journal of English Linguistics*, 40(3), 256-280.
- [2] Dinkin, A. J., & Dodsworth, R. (2017). Gradience, allophony, and chain shifts. *Language Variation and Change*, 29(1), 101-127.
- [3] Forrest, J. (2015). Community rules and speaker behavior: Individual adherence to group constraints on (ING). *Language Variation and Change*, 27(3), 377-406.